CASE STUDY | BUSINESS FINANCE INTERVIEW

Forecasting a 12-Month P&L for a Third-Party Contact Centre

Helix Support Partners· Forecast period: January 2026 – December 2026

Format	Duration	Deliverable	Tools
Take-home + 45-min defense session	3 hours preparation	Excel model + 5-slide summary	Excel / Google Sheets

1. Situation

Helix Support Partners is an independent, third-party contact center (a business-process outsourcer). It does not sell a product of its own: it operates customer-service teams on behalf of client companies — e-commerce marketplaces, fintechs, telcos and food-delivery platforms — and bills those clients for the work its agents perform.

Helix earns revenue in exactly two ways:

- Per handled call — an inbound voice contact answered by an agent. Billing is per call answered, not per minute.
- Per handled ticket — an asynchronous contact (email, in-app message, chat transcript or back-office task) resolved by an agent.

Commercial terms are set annually. The rate card for 2026 has already been agreed with clients and is fixed for the year; volumes are forecast jointly with clients and re-baselined quarterly. Helix carries the staffing risk: if volumes come in below plan it still pays for the agents it hired.

You have joined Helix as a finance business partner. The CFO has handed you the agreed 2026 topline and asked for a full operating plan.

2. Your task

Build a monthly profit-and-loss forecast for Helix for January 2026 through December 2026. Specifically:

1. Translate the topline in Exhibit A into a workload forecast (productive hours required per month).
2. Size the organization: derive the agent FTE requirement month by month, then add supervision, quality, workforce-management, training and support roles. State every ratio you assume.
3. Cost the organization: build the full cost stack — people, technology, telephony, facilities, recruitment and attrition, management and corporate overhead.
4. Produce the monthly P&L from revenue down to net profit, using the structure in Exhibit D. Report gross margin, EBITDA and EBITDA margin for each month and for the full year.
5. Derive the unit economics: revenue per call and per ticket, cost per call and per ticket, and contribution per contact. Explain which of the two revenue lines is more profitable and why.

Where the case does not give you a number, assume one — and say so. We are assessing how you reason, not whether you guess the same number we did.

3. Exhibit A — Given operating assumptions

These are Helix's measured 2025 actuals. Use them as your 2026 starting point.

Metric	2025 actual / assumption	Notes

Average handling time — call	**75 seconds**	Talk + hold + after-call work, per answered call
Average handling time — ticket	**40 seconds**	Per ticket resolved; includes re-reads and internal notes
Service level target — voice	**80% answered in 20s**	Contractual; breach triggers service credits
Service level target — tickets	**95% resolved < 4 hours**	Asynchronous, so no real-time queueing uplift needed
Occupancy	**78%**	Productive time as a share of logged-in time
Shrinkage	**30%**	Paid but unavailable: breaks, leave, sickness, training, coaching, meetings
Paid hours per agent per month	**176 hours**	22 working days × 8 hours
Span of control — team leader	**1 per 15 agents**	
Span of control — operations manager	**1 per 6 team leaders**	
Quality analysts	**1 per 40 agents**	Manual call/ticket scoring, 2% sample
Site leadership	**1 site director + 1 finance/HR business partner**	Fixed
Corporate tax rate	**22%**	Applied to profit before tax

4. Exhibit B — Given cost assumptions

All figures are illustrative and expressed in a single currency unit (shown as $). Restate them in your local currency if you prefer — the structure is what matters. Salaries are monthly gross; employer taxes, insurance and statutory benefits add 22% on top of gross for every role.

Cost item	Rate	Basis
Agent — gross monthly salary	**50 mln IRT**	Blended across shifts; includes an average $60 of shift and performance allowance
Team leader	**100 mln IRT**	Gross monthly
Quality analyst	40 mln IRT	Gross monthly
Operations manager	**150 mln IRT**	Gross monthly
Site director	**200 mln IRT**	Gross monthly
Finance / HR business partner	**150 mln IRT**	Gross monthly
Employer on-costs	**+22% of gross**	Social security, insurance, statutory benefits — all roles
Annual wage inflation	**+25% effective 1 April 2026**	Applied to all salary lines
Overtime	**0.5 mln IRT per hour**	Assume 3% of productive hours are covered by overtime

5.Exhibit C — 2026 Topline (agreed with clients)

Volumes and rate card for the forecast period. Shaded cells to be completed.

Driver	Jan-26	Feb-26	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26	Jun-26	Jul-26	Aug-26	Sep-26	Oct-26	Nov-26	Dec-26
VOLUME												
Inbound calls offered (#)	320k	360k	280k	300k	320k	360k	400k	420k	480k	490k	540k	500k
Call abandonment rate (%)	3%	4%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	4%	2%
Calls handled / billable (#)												
Tickets handled / billable (#)	210k	230k	180k	200k	210k	220k	250k	260k	320k	350k	400k	380k
RATE CARD												
Price per handled call (IRT)												
Price per handled ticket (IRT)												
Other / one-off fees (IRT)												
REVENUE (derived)												
Call revenue (IRT)												
Ticket revenue(IRT)												
Gross revenue(IRT)												

6.Exhibit D — Capacity and FTE build (Calculate)

Work from volume to workload hours to net productive hours per FTE to headcount. Do not jump straight to a headcount number.

7.Exhibit E — Profit & Loss, January–December 2026 (Create P&L)

Use this structure.

P&L line	Jan-26	Feb-26	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26	Jun-26	Jul-26	Aug-26	Sep-26	Oct-26	Nov-26	Dec-26	FY26

8.Exhibit F — Cost improvement program (Your Proposal for cost improvements)

Propose six to eight initiatives. Rank them by expected 12-month EBITDA impact net of investment. At least two must be deliverable within 90 days.

Initiative	Mechanism — what changes	Impact/Key risk / dependency
1.		
2.		
3.		